Direct Democracy

As form to prevent populism

A central way to preserve democracy is by strengthening forms of direct representation so citizens have meaningful, legitimate channels to influence policy. When people feel unheard or excluded from decision-making, populist actors can capitalize on that frustration by claiming they alone speak for "the people." Systems that broaden participation can reduce this vulnerability

Practical Example:

The ***LEGO Ideas* platform**, where ordinary users propose projects, gather community support, and through transparent thresholds and clear responses; see real outcomes. Its success shows how low-barrier, well-structured participation increases engagement, trust, and a sense that individual input matters.

Ineffective Example:



The UK already has mechanisms like public consultations and the ***Parliament petitions system***, but many participants feel that these channels are ignored or treated as symbolic rather than impactful. When feedback loops are weak or outcomes unclear, trust erodes, and the sense of being unheard grows; precisely the conditions under which populism thrives. Strengthening these systems so that proposals receive genuine consideration would help close the gap between citizens and policymakers.

Authoritarian Example:



Not all forms of "direct input" strengthen democracy. Hungary's ***Nemzeti Konzultáció*** shows how an authoritarian-leaning government can appropriate the language of participation while tightly controlling the process. The consultation surveys are framed in confusing ways that reinforce predetermined government positions, functioning more as propaganda than genuine representation. This highlights the importance of designing participatory mechanisms that are independent, transparent, and pluralistic.

Conclusion:

More robust direct representation can limit populist ascent by providing visible, institutional opportunities for people to express preferences and address unmet needs. When citizens have real avenues to influence policy, the appeal of anti-establishment rhetoric diminishes, and grievances are less easily transformed into populist mobilization. In short, authentic, well-designed systems of direct representation can increase trust, reduce grievance, and weaken the appeal of populists; while manipulated versions do the opposite. Strengthening direct input is therefore a key proposal for preserving democratic resilience.